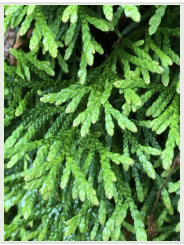
Northern White-Cedar, Arborvitae

Thuja occidentalis

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Overlook: 3 **TOTAL 3**



Summer / form
Library candidate

Not available

Fall color
Not available

Not available

Flower
Not available



Leaf close-up
Library candidate

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Evergreen
Mature size: 20–40 ft (up to 50+ ft). Confirmed by University of Minnesota (20–40 ft), multiple sources. × 10–15 ft. Narrower pyramidal.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Marginal for typical Zone 8a Atlanta. Hardy Zones 2–7. Native to northeastern U.S. and Canada (range to NC/TN mountains). Medium evergreen. Scale-like foliage, aromatic. Prefers cool moist alkaline soils. Sensitive to heat, drought, and winter burn in exposed sites. Performs better in cooler microclimates or with consistent moisture. Many cultivars. Not ideal for hot dry Atlanta urban sites. Restart pass (2026-10-13): NC State notes heat and drought sensitivity; better performance in cooler sites. Existing notes stand.
Sun: Full sun to part shade. Prefers some protection from hot afternoon sun.
Water: Medium to high. Prefers moist well-drained. Intolerant of prolonged drought.
Soil: Moist, well-drained, neutral to alkaline preferred. Tolerates clay. Avoid dry exposed sites.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun to part shade in moist well-drained soil. Mulch and water consistently. Protect from hot dry winds. Suitable for cooler protected Atlanta sites or as screen. Many cultivars for size and form. Minimal pruning. Better for higher elevation or moist microclimates.
Soil prep: Moist, well-drained, neutral to alkaline preferred. Tolerates clay. Avoid dry exposed sites.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Cool moist sites, swamps, cliffs, rocky areas. Northeastern range, higher elevations south.
Form / habit: Evergreen conifer. Medium tree or large shrub. Pyramidal. Slow to moderate growth. Often multi-stemmed or twisted trunk.
Foliage: Evergreen. No fall color. Winter interest.
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Reddish-brown, fibrous, peeling in strips.
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: Sensitive to heat, drought, winter desiccation. Possible bagworms, spider mites, deer browse. **Open:** Specific Zone 8a incidence and heat stress thin. Marginal for typical Atlanta.
Not stated
Additional:
- Scale-like aromatic foliage. - Pyramidal form. - Many cultivars. - Prefers cooler climates. - Marginal heat tolerance in Zone 8a. - Winter interest.

Sources: - University of Minnesota UFOR - NC State Extension - Multiple botanical references